

Q How do I give medicine to a wiggling baby?

Getting a baby to take medicine or tolerate drops being put in her eye can be one of the most exasperating tasks for parents. As much as possible, try to stay calm.

Your baby's distress coupled with your concern about helping her get better means that it is easy for both of you to end up in a tight ball of stress. Even if you don't feel calm, try to sound reassuring and be matter of fact. Time medicine for when your baby is most receptive, perhaps after being cuddled, or before being fed, when she's a little hungry and will swallow something.

ADMINISTERING MEDICINE AND DROPS

Before you give medicine or drops, always check that they haven't passed their use-by date, and after using, store the medicine or drops as recommended by the manufacturer or pharmacist.

» **Giving oral medicines:** these can be given via the syringe or dosage spoon provided by the manufacturer. For a very young baby, a syringe can be the easiest way to get the medicine into her mouth since the contents are less likely to be spilled. Also, up until about four months, your baby has a thrust reflex, which means she automatically pushes things out of her mouth, so it's easier to use a syringe. Draw up the correct dosage of medicine into the syringe. Hold your baby close to you in an upright position, and, if it helps, stroke her cheek to encourage her to open her mouth, then place the syringe in your baby's mouth. Let your baby suck on the syringe if she seems willing to, or squirt the contents slowly, or a little at a time, into the side, rather than the back, of her mouth, so she doesn't choke. If you use a spoon, gently tip the medicine into the mouth, giving small amounts at a time if this works best.

» **Administering eye drops:** if possible, get someone else to help you do this, with one of you holding your baby while the other gives the drops. You may also find wrapping your baby in a blanket helpful, if this doesn't distress her, so that she isn't able to thrash her arms and legs around. Wash your hands. With your baby laid flat or in a reclined position, gently pull down the lower eyelid, then squeeze one drop into

the lower lid, being careful not to touch any part of the eye with the dropper. Once you let go of the lid, your baby should blink, which helps to disperse the drop. If your baby won't allow you to pull down her lid, place the drop onto the side of the closed eye closest to the nose. Although not as effective, some of the fluid will hopefully make its way into the eye once open.

» **Administering saline nose drops:** your doctor or pharmacist may recommend these if a clogged nose is interfering with your baby's feeding or breathing. Wash your hands. As with eye drops, recruit a helper if possible. Wipe away any mucus. With your baby lying flat, place the dropper just inside the nostril and squeeze the right amount of drops into the nostril. Try to hold your baby in this position for a minute or so to help the drops spread through the nose.

» **Giving ear drops:** the sensation of liquid going into her ear may upset your baby and she may wiggle, so wrapping her in a blanket can help to keep her still while you give her the drops. Wash your hands. Lay your baby down and try to tilt her head to one side. Gently pull the ear lobe down to open up the ear canal, then squeeze the correct number of drops into the ear. Keep her in this position for a couple of minutes so that the drops can work their way into the ear.

Administering eye drops Do this as quickly and calmly as possible, talking to your baby constantly during the procedure to reassure her.



Did you know...

Breast-fed babies have a lower incidence of infections and illnesses during the first year of life, including gastrointestinal infections that lead to diarrhea and vomiting, respiratory tract infections, and recurrent ear infections. Studies also show that when breast-fed babies do catch an infection, this is likely to be less severe than in infants who aren't breast-fed. For example, breast-fed babies are far less likely than formula-fed babies to be hospitalized for respiratory illnesses.

Q How can I help protect my baby from catching bugs?

Infections are inevitable in babies and young children as their immune system builds up its resistance over time. However, there are a few things you can do to limit the number of infections your little one picks up. Breast-feeding for as long as possible is one of the best ways to keep your baby well, since your milk passes on protective antibodies. When your baby is very young, it's also good to limit, or avoid contact with people with colds and bugs. Throughout infancy, she'll be offered many vaccinations, so keep up with her scheduled immunization program.

Q How can I best comfort and take care of my baby when she is sick?

Taking care of a sick baby is a new experience for many parents, and understandably, anxiety can take hold of you. Keep in mind that your comforting presence is an important factor in keeping her calm, which in turn helps her body fight illness. Your baby feels less secure when she is sick, so staying close by, cuddling her, and talking soothingly will all help reassure her.

While young babies can go downhill quite rapidly, with the right attention they usually recover quickly too. Knowing what to look for, when to seek medical help, or when to tend to her at home, gives you the confidence that you're equipped to give her the right care.

